

behaviours, they follow ideas.”

Nayar draws inspiration from history to illustrate why personality is secondary to purpose. “Religious leaders are the best proof. They do not pay salaries, yet they inspire millions. Some are powerful orators, others remain silent for years, but both command loyalty even after their lifetimes. The reason is simple: followers are moved by the ideas they represent, not by how they say it,” he says. There is no one right answer, adds the IT industry veteran. “We needed Steve Jobs’ articulation during transformation, yet he picked his opposite in Tim Cook. Bill Gates did the opposite. Leadership is not about behaviour. The difference is conviction, not charisma. The real transformation people should attempt is moving from personality to purpose, from behaviour to belief.”

A NEW ERA?

Shivakumar rejects the idea of labelling a CEO as strictly extroverted or introverted. “Leadership behaviour is always in context,” he says. “If the company needs energy, the CEO has to step up on the extroverted aspects. If the company needs reflection, he or she needs to be introverted. The best CEOs know when to switch.” He says what defines effective leadership is connection and not personality type. “Connected leaders stay close to people in the organisation, to society, and to regulators. That connectedness matters far more than any label of introvert, extrovert, or ambivert.”

For Nayar, leadership boils down to belief, not personality. “The questions that matter the most are: What do I intrinsically believe in? And is that belief inspiring enough for others to follow?” he says. If a



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FORMER CEO OF NOKIA
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HOLDINGS; CHAIRMAN
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INDUSTRIES



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VINEET NAYAR
FOUNDER, SAMPARK
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CEO, HCL TECHNOLOGIES

leader’s belief system resonates, people rally around him or her with speed and intensity; if it doesn’t, no visibility or stage presence can compensate, says Nayar. In today’s transparent world, Nayar adds, belief systems are quickly revealed. “A leader who speaks of being ‘employee-first’ but takes actions that contradict it is exposed instantly. Consistency between belief and action matters far more than whether you are extroverted or introverted.”

While ambivert leaders are praised for balancing data with empathy, Nayar prefers a different framing: “Leaders anchored in belief have a compass that allows them to weigh both logic and intuition without losing direction.” Crises may favour extroverts who dominate the narrative, he says, but when the dust settles, belief-driven leadership sustains trust.

Parashar seconds that. “Look at Narayana Murthy, Azim Premji, and Ratan Tata, admired for conviction, not flamboyance. Even global icons like Satya Nadella and Sundar Pichai stand out for thoughtful presence, not theatrics,” she says.

Parashar says today’s leaders can’t operate on just one note. “They need to be ‘socially bilingual’, able to command attention, but also skilled at listening and reflecting,” she says. Data on Indian leaders reinforces this point: while they score high on recognition and power, they also value altruism, a desire to give back to the community and data-driven decisions. This calls for ambiversion. Parashar, in her coaching practice, often sees leaders realise that “I don’t need to always be the loudest voice. Sometimes the most powerful thing I can do is listen.” She